AJP Policy Document

Ending trapping and hunting for population control

AJP opposes the trapping and hunting of wild animals as a part of so-called 'pest control' activities. For AJP's policy on hunting for entertainment, see: *Hunting and Fishing policies*.

Common trapping practices include:

- Leg-Hold Traps: These devices are designed to capture animals by the limb, restraining them until they are dispatched by trappers. The use of leg-hold traps can result in severe injuries, including fractures, dislocations, and lacerations. Animals caught in these traps can experience prolonged periods of distress and pain before being euthanised.[1,2]
- Kill Traps: Intended to provide a swift death, even the most humane traps can kill non-target species or cause non-lethal injury.[3]
- Live-Capture Cage Traps: These traps aim to capture animals without immediate harm, allowing for relocation or euthanasia. Animals may experience stress, dehydration and exposure to harsh environmental conditions while confined for up to 24 hours, according to regulations. However, these regulations are not actively enforced.[4]

A lack of enforcement for existing codes of conduct means that inhumane practices persist with minimal accountability. This regulatory gap allows for the continuation of trapping and hunting methods that cause unnecessary suffering to animals.

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[1] Ministry for Primary Industries. (n.d.). *Restricted traps and devices*. New Zealand Government. https://www.mpi.govt.nz/animals/animal-welfare/animal-welfare-and-pest-management/traps-and-devices-used-to-manage-pests/restricted-traps-and-devices/

[2] Ministry for Primary Industries. (2011, December). *Leg-hold traps and the Animal Welfare Act 1999* [Fact sheet]. New Zealand Government. https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/1466-Leg-Hold-Traps-and-the-Animal-Welfare-Act-1999

[3] Ryan, E. A., Dubois, S., & Fraser, D. (2022). A Preliminary Evaluation of a Captive-bolt Trap for Commensal Rodents: Humaneness, Capture Efficiency, and Effect on Non-Target Species. *Canadian Wildlife Biology & Management (CWBM), 11(2)*.

[4] Ministry for Primary Industries. (n.d.). *Traps and devices used to manage pests*. New Zealand Government. https://www.mpi.govt.nz/animals/animal-welfare/animal-welfare-and-pest-management/traps-and-devices-used-to-manage-pests/

Children and young people in New Zealand are sometimes involved in trapping activities without sufficient age restrictions.[5] This exposure raises ethical concerns regarding the normalisation of violence towards animals and potential desensitisation to animal suffering. It also poses safety risks, as handling traps and captured animals can be hazardous without proper training and supervision.

Current trapping practices, coupled with inadequate regulation and enforcement, often result in significant, and unnecessary, animal suffering. Addressing these issues requires comprehensive policy and legislative reform, including the development and implementation of more humane control methods, stricter regulations and educational initiatives to promote ethical practices in wildlife management.

Key Objectives:

1. Amend the Animal Welfare Act to prohibit the unnecessary killing and suffering of all animals, requiring that population control be carried out with humane and non-lethal methods, and ensuring that greater accountability and stricter enforcement methods are upheld.

Interim Objectives:

While working toward long-term legislative change, AJP supports introducing more stringent regulations and safeguards to minimise harm to wild animals. These include:

1. **Mandatory live cameras on traps** to ensure compliance with animal welfare regulations and to facilitate immediate response once an animal is captured. Current legal requirements for trap checks every 12 hours are inadequate, and real-time monitoring would enable faster intervention to reduce suffering.
2. **Strict codes of conduct for hunting and trapping**, making ethical guidelines enforceable in legislation, rather than voluntary. AJP will advocate for uniform and legally binding standards across all hunting and trapping activities. (*aligns to Hunting and Fishing policies*)
3. **Age restrictions** to prohibit individuals under 18 from participating in trapping, hunting or any wild animal control activities that involve direct harm to animals.
4. **Stronger regulation of live trapping**, ensuring that any continued use of live traps adheres to high welfare standards, with a focus on transitioning toward non-lethal population management solutions.

[5] E.g. see https://thesavemovement.org/help-us-ban-violent-childrens-hunting-in-aotearoa-new-zealand/